

death." She left a job in an English department for the brokerage firm, enticed by the considerable increase in salary she got for analyzing cosmetics companies instead of Dylan Thomas.

About Gillette, Ms. Longley was halfway enthused, calling the stock a "moderate buy." That put her somewhere between Ms. Temple and Ms. Hall, but at this point, I'd become less interested in Gillette *per se* and more interested in what the analysts said about each other. I was caught up in their intrigue, fascinated with their odd preoccupation with their colleagues' opinions. Now that I'd been dragged into it, I told Ms. Longley that I felt like a messenger in some diplomatic plot. I explained that I'd been moving from office to office, serving as an unpaid spy for Ms. Hall. Why, I wondered, would such a thing be necessary?

Ms. Longley explained that analysts are not the lonely statisticians, poring over annual reports in the back rooms, that I might have imagined. They are a gregarious bunch and spend most of their waking hours on the telephone. All day they chat with important investors, jockeying for influence, hoping to be first in line with some new bit of information—an unusual jump in shampoo sales, an unexpected loss in the razor sector—that outdoes the previous caller. And although it is not the custom for rival analysts to communicate directly, their jobs may depend on what is being said about them. Each wants to be prepared for the latest gossip before he hears it from a big client's mouth.

To illustrate, Ms. Longley said she'd just returned from a visit to Avon. "I get back, sit down, and call everybody I know who owns the stock to tell them what I found out. That takes half a day." Meanwhile, her competitors like Mr. Raj or Ms. Temple may also have visited Avon, and they, too, are busily contacting the same investors to tell what they've found out. "I may call a client who just got off the phone with Diana Temple," explained Ms. Longley. "I'll hear from that client what Diana has been saying. He might say to me, 'Your earnings estimate of \$5.60 sounds low. Diana's projecting \$5.80.' "

As to where they got their information in the first place, Ms. Longley said most of it came straight from company headquarters. Each Gillette analyst called Boston two, three, even four times a